

GIREESH GV

FALL FROM GRACE:
Caged stray dogs



The Canine Chronicle

When dogs ruled history and literature. Debroy's book is a fascinating study of the relationship between man and the most indulged animal.



**SARAMA AND HER CHILDREN: THE
DOG IN INDIAN MYTH**
by BIBEK DEBROY
Penguin
Price: Rs 350; Pages: 243

■ By Bunny Suraiya

I never knew that there's a Harappan figurine of a pet dog, collar and all. I never knew that India exported dogs to Alexander the Great and the kings of Persia. I never knew of the Raja Ravi Varma painting that represents the four Vedas as dogs. I never knew that in 12th century Norway, a dog was appointed king for three years, signing all royal decrees with his paw prints. And most importantly of all, I never knew that the stray, who snuck into my home and my heart 10 years ago is actually a Rampur hound (though I must confess her fly-away ears betoken some admixture to the genes).

Bibek Debroy's book is a mine of information about dogs, and though the subtitle is 'The Dog in Indian Myth', the book covers much more than that. It is also about the dog in history, ancient and modern; the dog in literature, western and Indian; the dog in Greek, Roman and Egyptian mythology; and the dog in folk tales ranging from those of Aesop to the Brothers Grimm to the Panchatantra.

The research is exceedingly wide-ranging and the historical nuggets, literary quotations, mythological texts, folklore and current statistics relating to dogs come at you so thick and fast that they almost obscure the central thesis of the book: that the eponymous Sarama, (the dog of the gods in Vedic times) and her children, who are all the Indian dogs we see lolling on street sides, offering their friendship and often being kicked or stoned for their pains, have been victims of an attitude change that has relegated them from a near-divine status to being perceived as a social scourge. (Shockingly, even Mahatma Gandhi's ahimsa stopped short at dogs, with his call for "legislation making every stray dog liable to be shot").

Debroy makes out a convincing argument that this fall in status of the Indian dog, from the time of the Rig Veda, was paralleled by the rise of the Vaishnav Brahmanical tradition, which equated dogs with low caste Shudras—and women. But all is not lost. The dog is redeemed by Shiva and his avatars, especially those in the Shakti and Tantra traditions. And I, for one, completely agree with the last sentence in the book: "A faithful dog is indeed sometimes worth more than a brahmana family". I would only remove the word 'sometimes'.

Free Thoughts

An analysis of Indian experience in development economics



LIBERALIZATION AND DEVELOPMENT
by DEEPAK NAYYAR
Oxford
Price: Rs 795; Pages: 422



TRADE AND GLOBALIZATION
by DEEPAK NAYYAR
Oxford
Price: Rs 795; Pages: 457

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

It is but human to be biased for bias is embedded in the human DNA. But debate is expected to make room for all points of view. Most essayists and columnists aim at projecting a particular point and some, often, deliver a prismatic view on issues. It is, thus, refreshing to read a collection of essays that is robust in its analytical rigour and lucid in clarity. *Liberalization and Development* and *Trade and Globalization* the twin volumes of essays by Deepak Nayyar deliver both depth and understanding on two very complex issues that face most political economies. What makes the twin volumes worth their weight is that they focus on two segments of economic development that India has wrestled with internally and negotiated hard externally in its quest to attain its potential.

The first compendium *Liberalization and Development* looks at macro economic theory and alternative policy approach for developing countries in the context of a world where borders have been blurred by trade routes. The essays evaluate the India experience both in the historical and political context. The second volume again is a layered treat on understanding trade as it was and as it is evolving. Beginning with the free trade doctrine, the book in clearly demarcated sections looks at transnational corporations, regional trade blocs and, of course, India's engagement with the world of trade. The books are a must read for all students and practitioners of development economics.